

Understanding Ectopic Pregnancy

Needs Prompt Care

What it is, how it's found, and how it's treated

This is not your fault — an ectopic pregnancy can happen even with no known risk factors. Early diagnosis and treatment are the best ways to protect your health.

WHAT IS AN ECTOPIC PREGNANCY?

Implants Outside the Uterus

Normally a fertilized egg grows inside the uterus. In an ectopic pregnancy it implants **outside** the main cavity — most often in a fallopian tube.

⚠️ Why It's Serious

A pregnancy outside the uterus cannot develop normally. As it grows it can cause internal bleeding and become **life-threatening** if untreated.

Common Symptoms (may be mild at first)

- Vaginal spotting or bleeding
- Lower abdominal/pelvic pain, often on one side
- Cramping or low back pain
- Pain with bowel movements or urination

CALL 911 / GO TO THE ER

Get emergency care right away for:

- **911** Sudden, severe, or worsening abdominal/pelvic pain
- **911** Shoulder pain, especially with weakness or dizziness
- **911** Fainting, feeling very lightheaded, or racing heartbeat
- **911** Heavy vaginal bleeding
- **911** Severe weakness, pale or clammy skin, feeling very unwell

These can be signs of internal bleeding from a ruptured ectopic pregnancy and need immediate care.

HOW IS IT DIAGNOSED?

- **Pregnancy test** — urine or blood test confirms pregnancy.
- **Blood tests (hCG)** — the pregnancy hormone is often checked twice, ~48 hours apart. The trend helps guide diagnosis but can't confirm ectopic by itself.
- **Transvaginal ultrasound** — a small probe looks closely at the uterus, tubes, and ovaries.
- **Physical exam** — checks for tenderness, bleeding, or signs of internal bleeding.

Sometimes it's too early to see on ultrasound (a "**pregnancy of unknown location**"). Repeat blood tests and ultrasounds are important until the location and outcome are clear.

TREATMENT OPTIONS

Treatment depends on your symptoms, ultrasound, hCG levels, health, and pregnancy goals.

- 1 **Close monitoring** — if hCG is already low and falling, the body may resolve it on its own. Requires reliable follow-up blood tests.
- 2 **Methotrexate** — an injection that stops the pregnancy from growing, if unruptured and you're stable. Needs repeat hCG tests over weeks; some need another dose or surgery.
- 3 **Surgery** — for rupture, internal bleeding, or when medication isn't right. Usually laparoscopy; the tube may be preserved or removed.

Future Fertility & Emotional Support

Many people go on to have a healthy pregnancy after an ectopic pregnancy, though the risk of another is somewhat higher — in a future pregnancy, contact us **early** for hCG testing and an early ultrasound. This can also be emotionally hard; grief, sadness, and anxiety are common, and support from loved ones, counseling, or a pregnancy-loss group can help. **Remember:** a positive pregnancy test with pelvic/abdominal pain, bleeding, dizziness, or shoulder pain needs urgent evaluation. Call us anytime at **(281) 557-0300**.